

Chapter 4 – The Rich Social Lives of Amazonian Animals

What I looked forward to most was watching the parrots gather for their morning clay lick—one of the Amazon's most spectacular daily rituals. Hundreds of parrots congregate along a clay cliff by the river: tiny parakeets, medium-sized parrots, and even macaws nearly a meter tall. Living on a diet of unripe fruit, they rely on the mineral-rich clay to obtain salts and natural detoxifying compounds.



At dawn, as the first strand of sunlight spills over the treetops, the parrots assemble near the cliff but don't descend right away. Instead, they chatter excitedly, filling the air with gossip lively enough to cover the whole rainforest. With lifespans of up to eighty years and homes perched high in the canopy, if any creature could recount the full history of the Amazon, it would surely be the parrot. I wish I understood what they were saying.

